Since the end of August 1959, the defence minister had been taking every possible opportunity to further humiliate Thimayya. As the Karam Singh drama unfolded, Menon decided to further up the ante against the hapless army chief. The announcement on 1 November that the army would take control of Ladakh, akin to the earlier statement made vis-à-vis NEFA after the Longju incident, was perhaps aimed more at Thimayya than the Chinese. For the political survival of both Prime Minister Nehru (and Defence Minister Krishna Menon) it was now important that the dovish image Nehru had so carefully cultivated, even to the extent of lying to his people over half a decade about the Chinese intentions, had to be replaced by a hawkish one.

Indian leaders who had not been blindsided by the Panchsheel Treaty and the 'Hindi Chini bhai-bhai' propaganda had regularly voiced their concern since the early 1950s. In April 1959, after the Chinese crackdown on Lhasa, Ram Manohar Lohia was vocal in saying India simply had to take its head out of the sand: 'When the "Baby Murder" in Tibet took place nine years ago most of the people who today are raising a hue and cry over the second instalment of Chinese assault on the Tibetan people were, as far as I remember, silent. Something ought to have been done then, something ought to have been said. Which, however, does not mean that nothing should be said now. But while saying it, people should not forget their weaknesses; as they say, when the peacock dances it should do well to be aware of its legs.'

But these warnings had fallen on deaf ears. By then, in the corridors of power in New Delhi, there were too many political games being played; games that would all contribute to the fate of the Indian soldiers who were then soon to be committed in both NEFA and Ladakh.

WRONG TROOPS, WRONG PLACE, WRONG TIME

By the end of 1959, 4 Division was on the move from Punjab to the plains of Assam for deployment in NEFA. Structured, equipped and trained for warfare in the plains, its transport and artillery were not suitable for fighting in the mountains, just as its officers and men had no real idea of how to fight even tactical battles in completely different circumstances. Despite the fighting in Kashmir a decade ago, Indian infantry divisions were still designed to fight the Burma campaign in World War II. Already, neither the CGS, nor the Eastern Army Commander nor the COAS were in the